LIFE AND LETTERS

Anuradha Roy on winning the Sahitya Akademi award, a favourite character from one of her novels, and the state of scholarship in India

Q. Your last novel, *The Earthspinner*, was a delight for many. Are there any new themes you're considering right now, either in your mind or on the page?
I am almost always writing...and almost never like talking about it. But it takes me time to come out from the world of one novel and breathe the air of another.

Q. Your novel, *All the Lives We Never Lived*, was widely praised by critics the world over, but does seeing it win a Sahitya Akademi award feel special?
This award is like no other—it places my novel alongside the work of so many writers I have grown up reading. It makes me feel as if I am part of a long tradition of Indian writing in English. It is also unique in that it is decided upon by an independent jury despite being a state award.

Q. It was in the year 2000 that you co-founded the academic imprint Permanent Black. I want to ask, is scholarship in India alive and well?
It's alive, but maybe not very well, given that the room for dissent has shrunk in the present day. Self-censorship and exciting scholarship don't go together.

with Shreevatsa Nevatia

Q. Of all the historical figures in your novel, did any one grow to become a favourite character in the end?
Walter Spies is my favourite historical character in this book. Despite his genius, he seems not to have a grain of self-importance. He was sympathetic to animals and his capacity for joy and creativity could not be crushed by anything, not even internment or prison.



RAJWANT RAWAT